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A long history of failure

During the Cultural Revolution in China, there was a cult of personality surrounding Chairman Mao. In public, everyone claimed that Chairman Mao was their great leader, who had their best interests at heart, and had the right answers to all policy questions. Chairman Mao extolled practical knowledge and denigrated intellectualism.

One day, Chairman Mao organized millions of people to kill all the sparrows in China, on the grounds that sparrows eat grain.

Suppose we are willing to ignore the ethical problems associated with killing sparrows, and suppose we are willing to agree that this is a good objective as it would increase the amount of grain available to humans. Even then, the intervention failed.

With the sparrows removed from the scene, the insect population surged, and the insects ate the grain. Chairman Mao may have had good intentions, and he may have had practical experience of sparrows eating grain, but the intellectual foundation of the intervention was faulty.

The problems of state intervention

The murder of sparrows in China may appear to be an extreme example. It is not an exception. Across a large number of situations, state intervention works poorly.

Safety of the people is the most important function of the state. But after 9 p.m., over half of New Delhi feels it is unsafe to go to an ATM, and 90